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Mahatma Gandhi Institute of
Education for Peace and
Sustainable Development

Skill 7:Empathic Concern

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define Empathy and differentiate it from sympathy
- Identify the two types of empathy: affective and cognitive empathy.
- Identify thinking traps against empathy.
- Recognize the significance of Empathic Concern
- Explain empathic distress and the strategies to reduce it
- Apply strategies to cultivate sympathetic joy

What Does Empathy mean?

Empathy is the ability to understand and share the feelings, thoughts, and motivations of someone else. But it's important to ask ourselves if our empathy is always reasonable or if just feeling empathy is enough.

Empathy comes naturally to us because of something called **“emotional contagion.”** This is when emotions and behaviors automatically spread from one person to another. For example, when you see someone yawn, you might feel like yawning too. Or if someone in a room is very anxious, their anxiety can make everyone else feel tense as well.

From an evolutionary perspective, **emotional contagion** is helpful because it allows us to react to danger quickly. For instance, if you see someone suddenly look scared and start running, your instinct might be to run too, even if you don't know why. This quick reaction can keep us safe.

Emotional contagion can happen through things like facial expressions, body language, and tone of voice. While it's not the same as full empathy, emotional contagion shows that the roots of empathy are deeply embedded in our nature and history.

Next, we'll explore the two types of empathy.

Affective and Cognitive Empathy

Affective Empathy

Affective empathy is when we emotionally connect with someone else's feelings. For example, if a friend is feeling very sad, you might feel sad too, as if you're sharing their pain. Similarly, if a loved one has something great happen to them, you might feel happy just because they are happy.

Cognitive Empathy

Cognitive empathy is when we use our thinking skills to understand what someone else is going through, even if we don't feel their emotions ourselves. This is often called "putting yourself in someone else's shoes." For instance, if a coworker is stressed about a deadline, you might not feel stressed yourself, but you can understand why they are feeling that way by imagining yourself in their situation.

Both types of empathy help us connect with others, but in different ways—one through shared emotions, and the other through understanding.

Thinking traps to Empathy and strategies to overcome thinking traps

In-Group Bias	We naturally feel more empathy for people who are like us or part of our "in-group," such as friends or family. However, we may feel less empathy for people outside our group, like strangers or people we see as different. This bias can limit our empathy and harm our ability to connect with others. Example: You might feel deep sympathy for a friend who's going through a tough time but feel indifferent to a similar story you heard about in the news.
One-Over-Many	Research shows that we tend to feel the most empathy when we see one person suffering, but as the number of people suffering increases, our empathy can decrease. This doesn't make sense because we should feel more empathy when more people are in need.

	Example: You might feel a strong urge to help when you hear about one child in need, but when you hear about a large group of children suffering, the emotional impact might be less.
Empathic Distress	Sometimes, we feel overwhelmed by others' suffering, leading to feelings of hopelessness or burnout. This can make us want to shut down or give up trying to help. Example: You might feel so overwhelmed by the scale of a global crisis that you feel powerless to make a difference and end up doing nothing.
Jealousy/Envy	When we see someone else experiencing something positive, especially if we see them as a rival, we might feel jealous or envious. This thinking trap can make us believe that someone else's success takes away from our own happiness. Example: If a coworker gets a promotion, you might feel envious and think that their success means you're less successful.

Remember Our Common Humanity	To overcome in-group bias, we can practice seeing everyone as part of the same human family. By recognizing that we're all connected and dependent on each other, we can extend our empathy beyond just those who are close to us. Example: Instead of only feeling empathy for people you know, you might remind yourself that everyone, even strangers, shares the same basic needs and feelings.
Use Cognitive Empathy	To address the one-over-many trap, we can use logic to realize that caring for many people in need is just as important, if not more so, than caring for one person. Cognitive empathy helps us understand others' situations without getting overwhelmed by emotions.

	Example: If you hear about a large group of people suffering, try to put yourself in their shoes and think about how you would feel in their situation, rather than just reacting emotionally.
Cultivate Self-Compassion	To manage empathic distress, we can practice self-compassion by taking care of our own emotional needs and building resilience. This helps us stay strong and continue to help others without getting overwhelmed. Example: If you're feeling burned out from helping others, take some time for self-care and remind yourself that it's okay to need a break.
Practice Sympathetic Joy	To overcome jealousy and envy, we can practice feeling joy for others' successes and good fortune. Recognizing that someone else's success doesn't take away from our own happiness can help us feel more connected and less isolated. Example: If a friend achieves something great, instead of feeling envious, try to genuinely celebrate their success and feel happy for them.

Empathy and Bias

Empathic distress happens when we become overwhelmed by someone else's suffering. This overwhelming feeling can lead to burnout, where we feel so drained and hopeless that we start to shut down emotionally. For example, if you're constantly exposed to stories of people in pain, you might start feeling so much sadness that you begin to feel numb and unable to help.

Empathic distress often occurs because our empathy is biased—we tend to feel more empathy for people who are like us or who we see as part of our group, while feeling less for those we consider "others." This narrow focus can make our empathy irrational and limited, leading to problems when we face situations that require broader understanding and action.

However, there's a way to overcome empathic distress by cultivating empathic concern. Unlike empathic distress, which is focused on our own emotional reaction to others' suffering, empathic concern is about genuinely caring for the needs of others without getting

overwhelmed. It allows us to respond to suffering with compassion and helpful actions, rather than feeling paralyzed by it.

To develop empathic concern, we need to expand our empathy beyond just those we relate to. By practicing seeing everyone as part of the same human family, we can broaden our perspective and make empathy a more effective tool for supporting compassion and ethical behavior.

Sympathetic Joy

Sympathetic joy is the ability to feel happiness for someone else's good fortune or success. Instead of feeling jealous or envious when others do well, we genuinely share in their joy and celebrate their achievements as if they were our own. This quality helps us build stronger, more positive relationships and contributes to our own happiness.

How to Cultivate Sympathetic Joy:

1. Practice Gratitude:

- Start by appreciating the good things in your own life. When you regularly practice gratitude for what you have, it becomes easier to feel joy for others without comparing yourself to them.
- **Example:** If a friend gets a promotion, instead of feeling envious, remind yourself of the good things in your own career and genuinely celebrate their success. Try to imagine the amount of hard work or struggle he/she would have put in to reach here which you might not be aware of just because he/she never discussed about that.

2. Reflect on Interdependence:

- Recognize that we are all interconnected and that others' success can benefit you, too. When someone else does well, it can create a positive impact on your community or group.
- **Example:** If a colleague wins an award, think about how their success brings recognition to your team, which can open up more opportunities for everyone including you

3. Practice tools for emotional regulation

- Several times we might feel negative emotions when we are emotionally dysregulated. Using tools like tracking, grounding or resourcing will help you feel regulated and think clearly.
- **Example:** When you notice a wave of envy, pause for a moment and track your sensations to see where you feel them in your body. You can then use grounding or resourcing to regulate your emotions and get back into the resilient zone.

